A SITAR IS BORN

Q+A RISHAB RIKHIRAM SHARMA | MUSICIAN

Rishab Rikhiram Sharma's virtuosity with the sitar has made him popular on social media. Excerpts from the 26-year-old's session at the India Today Conclave:

Q. Has the sitar made Rishab popular or is Rishab popularising the sitar?
Both. I used to play the guitar but I was just drawn to the sound of the sitar...its natural reverberation. We have six top strings but 13 sympathetic strings that are tuned to a particular raag. So, if you play one note, there are four other strings that resonate along with it.

Q. Is there a rapper or rockstar in you?
I would say so, because I don't try to stick to a typical Indian classical image. My music is a reflection of who I am as a person. I listen to rappers such as Kanye and Playboi Carti. I've never had a filter, even though my gurus were like, 'just listen to classical music'.

Q. You don't always dress like a classical musician. Is it because you are catering to a generation that measures musical success by how viral it becomes?
I don't like how they (classical musicians) dress, so I was like, 'I am gonna start a fashion line of cool clothes for classical musicians to wear'. Even the mehendi on my hands is a reflection of that.

Q. Does criticism from the purists bother you?
I get criticised for my music, especially by the purists, but I have made my peace with it. My music is deeply rooted in tradition. My family, who are in the business of making instruments, are trying to bring back the surbahar. At the end of the day, as long as children are picking up the sitar instead of a guitar, that is a win for us.

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